



ARLINGTON COUNTY, VIRGINIA

County Board Agenda Item
Meeting of March 14, 2026

DATE: March 11, 2026

SUBJECT: Ranked Choice Voting for Upcoming General Elections

ISSUES: In February 2025, the Arlington County Board extended pilot use of Ranked Choice Voting (RCV) to its November 2025 County Board general election. The Board must decide whether to continue the use of RCV, otherwise the November 2026 general election will revert to the previous winner-take-all voting method. State law provides that any changes to an election must occur at least 90 days before such an election. Below are the following options the Board can consider:

- A. Extend pilot use of RCV for an additional year, to the upcoming 2026 County Board General Election;
- B. Extend pilot use of RCV for an additional 2 years, to the upcoming 2026 and 2027 County Board General Elections; and
- C. Establish the use of RCV permanently in all future County Board General Elections.

SUMMARY: The Board will consider the above options and will decide how to proceed with the use of the Ranked Choice Voting in upcoming County Board general elections.

BACKGROUND: Arlington's County Board has five at-large members, who each serve staggered 4-year terms. One (1) seat is up for election every year, with two (2) seats up for election every fourth year. Prior to 2023, the Board exclusively used a winner-take-all voting method in both its primary and general elections. Under this method, voters vote for the number of open seats that year, and the candidate(s) must receive a majority or plurality of votes to win. RCV is a voting method in which voters rank candidates in order of preference. All first choice votes are counted.

If no candidates receive the required number of votes to win, the candidate with the fewest votes is eliminated and ballots for that candidate are transferred to the voter's next choice. This process continues until candidates have enough votes to win. In one-seat elections, the threshold to win is 50% and one vote. In two-seat elections, candidates must secure 33% and one vote to win in an election determined by RCV.

DISCUSSION: In July 2020, the Virginia General Assembly passed a bill to amend the Code of Virginia [section 24.2-673.1] to allow localities to implement RCV in elections of members of a county board of supervisors or a city council. The Arlington County Board has incrementally expanded its use of RCV in its Board elections since 2022. RCV was first piloted in the June 2023 County Board primary and then adopted in December 2023 as the method for all future County Board primary elections. Since 2024, the County Board has piloted RCV in its general elections. It is considering:

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- A. (Attachment A): Extending pilot use of RCV for an additional year, to the upcoming 2026 County Board General Election;
- B. (Attachment B) Extending pilot use of RCV for an additional two years, to the upcoming 2026 and 2027 County Board General Elections; and
- C. (Attachment C) Establishing the use of RCV permanently in all future County Board General Elections.

PUBLIC ENGAGEMENT: *Level of Engagement:* Communicate & Consult

Below is a timeline since public engagement first began on this topic.

- **July 2021:** The Arlington Electoral Board began its discussions after HB506, the state-enabling legislation, took effect in July 2021. At its public meetings, the Electoral Board reviewed analyses of [Ranked Choice Voting and its application in Arlington](#).
- **August 2021:** The Arlington Office of Elections held a community event at the Bozman Government Center to educate and inform about RCV. Participants completed a model RCV ballot in a mock election facilitated by Elections staff and volunteers to select Arlington's favorite farmer's market, followed by a town-hall style Q&A about the implementation of RCV.
- **October 2021:** The County Board held a work session with the Electoral Board and Registrar on the RCV. This [work session](#) allowed County Board members to learn about RCV, its impacts on voters, and the specifics of tabulation. The conversation also surfaced related issues, such as independent local elections of School Boards (not eligible for RCV under state code).
- **Fall 2022:** The County Board invited public input on the pilot use of RCV in the 2023 County Board primary election. The Board received more than 780 survey responses. Seventy-five percent of respondents favored implementing RCV, and a zip code analysis indicated that feedback from each region of the County was favorable, with the lowest favorability in 22207, at 63%, and the highest in 22203, at 88%.
- **December 2022:** At its December 2022 Regular meeting, the [Board adopted RCV](#) as the election method in the 2023 County Board primary election. In the following six months, the County Office of Elections completed 20 RCV outreach events in the County, provided 16 election office training classes on the tabulation process, and provided training for candidates and their campaigns.
- **June 2023:** The County Board invited the public a second time to [provide feedback](#) on their opinions on and experiences with RCV in the primary election using a feedback form that closed on July 5, 2023. The Board received 2450 participants' responses, with 2109 comments. Of those that provided demographic information (n ranged from 1308 to 1368), 54% were 60+ in age, 89% were white, 83% owned their home, and 63% lived in a single-family, detached house.

- The majority of responses were positive and supported some future implementation of RCV. When asked to rate their experience with RCV, 57% of respondents indicated “positive” or “exceptional,” while 29% and 13% indicated “negative” and “fair,” respectively. 47% of respondents also believed that RCV should be implemented in every election, while 7% stated it should only be implemented in primaries. 32% believed that RCV should not be implemented at all, and 12% reported that they didn’t know enough to take a position.
- When asked about their familiarity with RCV before they voted, 56% stated they heard about it and understood it, 22% stated they were familiar, 19% said they heard about it but didn’t understand it, and 4% said they never heard about RCV. Respondents were also asked to select all the different ways they heard about RCV, and the top five were “News” (74%), Advocacy or Political Organization (40%), Friends or Family (30%), the County Website (29%) and the Elections Office Education Campaign (27%).
- **October 2024:** The Board repeated its [previous community feedback collection process](#) for the 2024 County Board general election. The feedback form closed on November 30, 2024, receiving over 1100 responses and 1068 comments. Respondents that provided demographic information (n ranged from 974 to 1036), 40% were 60+, 72% were white, 72% owned their home, and 52% lived in a single-family, detached house.
 - A slight majority of responses were positive and supported some future implementation of RCV. When asked to rate their experience RCV, 50% of respondents indicated “positive” or “expectational”, while 38% and 12% indicated “negative” and “fair”, respectively. 49% of respondents also believed that RCV should be implemented in every election, while 8% stated it should only be implemented in primaries. 39% believed that RCV should not be implemented at all, and 4% reported that they didn’t know enough to take a position.
- **Summer 2025:** In June, the Board [announces](#) a funding opportunity for RCV education and outreach and [sought proposals](#) from nonpartisan organizations with demonstrated experience in civic engagement, education, and community outreach.
- **Fall 2025:** In August, the Board [awarded](#) grants to two non-profits organizations, [Challenging Racism](#) and [FairVote](#) for voter education, outreach, and surveying efforts related to Ranked Choice Voting leading up to the November 2025 election. Challenging Racism was tasked with the education and outreach components, while Ranked Choice Virginia (the main partner organization operating under FairVote) was tasked with surveying and data evaluation.
- **February 2025:** Both non-profits provided their findings ([Challenging Racism’s report](#); [Ranked Choice Virginia’s report](#)) at the February 2025 Recessed Board meeting. Challenging Racism partnered with other local organizations to conduct 12 education events and 14 outreach activities. Ranked Choice Virginia’s reported several key findings

from its survey which included: 96% of voters were confident marking their ballots: 80% “very confident” and 16% “mostly confident”; 87% of voters understood the ballot counting process: 62% “confident” and 25% “pretty sure”; 66% of voters support using RCV in future general elections for Arlington County Board: 36% “strongly” and 30% “somewhat”.

- A notable recommendation of RCVa’s survey was the need for additional Spanish-language and Latino voter outreach. Latino voters consistently reported the least familiarity with RCV in the survey sample. Less than half (45%) knew they would be using RCV before they received their ballots, and 23% reported they were not sure or did not understand how ballots were counted. Latino voters also showed the least support for continued RCV use across ethnic groups, though net support was still positive at +19 points.

FISCAL IMPACT: The County's current voting machines supported RCV with ranking up to three choices in the 2024 and 2025 County Board general elections. If extended as the method of election for the 2026 County Board general election, these same machines will be used. The Adopted Fiscal Year (FY) 2023-2024 Capital Improvement Plan (CIP) provides funding for the replacement of the current voting machines in FY 2026 at a cost of \$2,000,000.

Additionally, approving the use of RCV in the 2026 General Election could potentially require additional funding due to the need for a 3-page or 2-card ballot. Virginia Code section 24.2-613(D) requires that all offices on the ballot appear before any questions presented to voters. Ballot standards adopted by the State Board of Elections also require that offices using RCV appear on their own side of a ballot. The Virginia Department of Elections granted waivers to this requirement previously and may do so again this year. Should a waiver not be granted, this additional page for each ballot will result in an estimated additional cost of \$60,000.

The Board may also consider, as part of its FY27 Budget process, funding for future education and outreach efforts on RCV. Whether to fund, and the level of funding, will be determined through this budget process.

ATTACHMENT A

ADOPT AN UNCODIFIED ORDINANCE TO EXTEND USE OF RANKED CHOICE VOTING TO THE 2026 COUNTY BOARD GENERAL ELECTION.

BE IT ORDAINED by the County Board of Arlington, Virginia, that the following uncoded ordinance is hereby adopted, and the use of ranked choice voting as the election method is hereby extended to the 2026 County Board General Election.

WHEREAS, ranked choice voting (RCV) means the method of casting and tabulating votes in which voters rank candidates in order of preference, tabulation proceeds in sequential rounds in which last-place candidates are defeated and the candidates with the most votes in the final round are nominated; and

WHEREAS, in July 2021, the Virginia General Assembly amended the Code of Virginia (§ 24.2-673.1) to allow localities to implement RCV in elections of members of a county board of supervisors or a city council, and the decision to conduct an election by ranked choice voting shall be made, in consultation with the local electoral board and general registrar, by a majority vote of the board of supervisors or city council that the office being elected serves; and

WHEREAS, the Electoral Board and Registrar of Arlington County, Virginia have engaged in educational efforts since 2021, including conducting a mock election using the application of RCV, a work session with the Arlington County Board to introduce and establish familiarity among stakeholders of the process of RCV, and numerous training sessions since the adoption of RCV as the election method for the June 2023 County Board primary election; and

WHEREAS, the use of RCV in the June 2023 primary elections for Arlington County Board allowed for the introduction of this new method to our community, and the Office of Elections reported no technical difficulty in administering this election; and

WHEREAS, the County Board adopted the use of RCV in all County Board primary elections at its December 2023 meeting; and

WHEREAS, the County Board piloted the use of RCV in the 2024 and 2025 County Board general elections to introduce this new method to more of the voting population, and allowed the Board to monitor and gauge its reception to help decide in future implementation in general elections; and

WHEREAS, the County Board extending the use of RCV to the upcoming 2026 County Board general election will allow for continuing monitoring of implementation and public reception of the voting method; and

WHEREAS, state law provides that any changes to an election must occur at least 90 days before such election and with the passage of this resolution Arlington County is compliant, and adoption of this resolution more than four months before the general election allows the

Arlington County Registrar additional time to educate and engage the community on the election method;

NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT ORDAINED, that the County Board of Arlington County, Virginia, hereby extends the use of RCV as the election method to the 2026 County Board general election.

Adopted the 14th day of March 2026

ATTACHMENT B

ADOPT AN UNCODIFIED ORDINANCE TO EXTEND USE OF RANKED CHOICE VOTING TO THE 2026 AND 2027 COUNTY BOARD GENERAL ELECTIONS.

BE IT ORDAINED by the County Board of Arlington, Virginia, that the following uncoded ordinance is hereby adopted, and the use of ranked choice voting as the election method is hereby extended to the 2026 and 2027 County Board General Elections.

WHEREAS, ranked choice voting (RCV) means the method of casting and tabulating votes in which voters rank candidates in order of preference, tabulation proceeds in sequential rounds in which last-place candidates are defeated and the candidates with the most votes in the final round are nominated; and

WHEREAS, in July 2021, the Virginia General Assembly amended the Code of Virginia (§ 24.2-673.1) to allow localities to implement RCV in elections of members of a county board of supervisors or a city council, and the decision to conduct an election by ranked choice voting shall be made, in consultation with the local electoral board and general registrar, by a majority vote of the board of supervisors or city council that the office being elected serves; and

WHEREAS, the Electoral Board and Registrar of Arlington County, Virginia have engaged in educational efforts since 2021, including conducting a mock election using the application of RCV, a work session with the Arlington County Board to introduce and establish familiarity among stakeholders of the process of RCV, and numerous training sessions since the adoption of RCV as the election method for the June 2023 County Board primary election; and

WHEREAS, the use of RCV in the June 2023 primary elections for Arlington County Board allowed for the introduction of this new method to our community, and the Office of Office of Elections reported no technical difficulty in administering this election; and

WHEREAS, the County Board adopted the use of RCV in all County Board primary elections at its December 2023 meeting; and

WHEREAS, the County Board piloted the use of RCV in the 2024 and 2025 County Board general elections to introduce this new method to more of the voting population, and allowed the Board to monitor and gauge its reception to help decide in future implementation in general elections; and

WHEREAS, the County Board extending the use of RCV to the upcoming 2026 and 2027 County Board general elections will allow for continuing monitoring of implementation and public reception of the voting method; and

WHEREAS, state law provides that any changes to an election must occur at least 90 days before such election and with the passage of this resolution Arlington County is compliant, and adoption of this resolution more than four months before the general election allows the

Arlington County Registrar additional time to educate and engage the community on the election method;

NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT ORDAINED that the County Board of Arlington County, Virginia, hereby extends the use of RCV as the election method to the 2026 and 2027 County Board general elections.

Adopted the 14th day of March 2026

ATTACHMENT C

ADOPT AN UNCODIFIED ORDINANCE TO ESTABLISH THE USE OF RANKED CHOICE VOTING IN ALL FUTURE COUNTY BOARD GENERAL ELECTIONS.

BE IT ORDAINED by the County Board of Arlington, Virginia, that the following uncoded ordinance is hereby adopted, and the use of ranked choice voting as the election method is hereby established for all future County Board General Elections.

WHEREAS, ranked choice voting (RCV) means the method of casting and tabulating votes in which voters rank candidates in order of preference, tabulation proceeds in sequential rounds in which last-place candidates are defeated and the candidates with the most votes in the final round are nominated; and

WHEREAS, in July 2021, the Virginia General Assembly amended the Code of Virginia (§ 24.2-673.1) to allow localities to implement RCV in elections of members of a county board of supervisors or a city council, and the decision to conduct an election by ranked choice voting shall be made, in consultation with the local electoral board and general registrar, by a majority vote of the board of supervisors or city council that the office being elected serves; and

WHEREAS, the Electoral Board and Registrar of Arlington County, Virginia have engaged in educational efforts since 2021, including conducting a mock election using the application of RCV, a work session with the Arlington County Board to introduce and establish familiarity among stakeholders of the process of RCV, and numerous training sessions since the adoption of RCV as the election method for the June 2023 County Board primary election; and

WHEREAS, the use of RCV in the June 2023 primary elections for Arlington County Board allowed for the introduction of this new method to our community, and the Office of Office of Elections reported no technical difficulty in administering this election; and

WHEREAS, the County Board adopted the use of RCV in all County Board primary elections at its December 2023 meeting; and

WHEREAS, the County Board piloted the use of RCV in the 2024 and 2025 County Board general elections to introduce this new method to more of the voting population, and allowed the Board to monitor and gauge its reception to help decide in future implementation in general elections; and

WHEREAS, state law provides that any changes to an election must occur at least 90 days before such election and with the passage of this resolution Arlington County is compliant, and adoption of this resolution more than four months before the general election allows the Arlington County Registrar additional time to educate and engage the community on the election method;

NOW, THEREFORE, BE IT ORDAINED, that the County Board of Arlington County, Virginia, hereby establishes the use of RCV as the election method in all future County Board General Elections.

Adopted the 14th day of March 2026